夺命毒雾：伦敦1952

The Killer Smog of 1952



温暖的炉火为何变成致命烟雾？

英文原文

On Friday 5 December 1952, cold, **stagnant** air **descended on** London. **Overhead**, warmer air pressed down like a **lid**, holding the **chill captive** beneath. Londoners were **accustomed to murky**, **dreary** winters. This time, though, the capital's smoke was trapped too, thickening into a **choking smog**, a mix of **smoke** and **fog**.

That smoke, from coal burned in **domestic fireplaces** and **power stations**, was **laden with** soot and **noxious** sulphur dioxide. In places, **visibility** fell to a few metres. **Ambulance** services were **suspended**, an opera at the Sadler's Wells theatre was abandoned at the **interval**, and prize **cattle** at the Smithfield **agricultural** show died or had to be **slaughtered**.

The smog **dissipated** on Tuesday 9 December. Officials at the time put the **excess** deaths at about 4,000, but a 1954 Ministry of Health report blamed later deaths on **influenza**. A study published in Environmental Health Perspectives in 2001 **reassessed** the evidence and **cast doubt on** that **explanation**, estimating about 12,000 excess deaths between December 1952 and February 1953.

For decades Londoners had **tolerated** the smoke as a **nuisance**. One **villain flickered** in their own grates, a source of **warmth** and **comfort** so **habitual** that few thought to **accuse** it. Such **complacency** may help to explain the government's **grudging response**. It **withstood** pressure for an **inquiry** until May 1953.

Reform proved **protracted**, slowed by official **inertia**. The Clean Air **Act** became law on 5 July 1956, three and a half years after the smog. It **empowered municipal** councils to create **smokeless** zones, **combating** smoke at its **source**. The **cosy hearth**, **beloved of** British families, had, all along, been among the chief **offenders**.

中文译文

1952年12月5日星期五，寒冷、凝滞的空气笼罩降临了伦敦。头顶上方，较暖的空气压了下来，像盖子一样，把寒气困在下面。伦敦人早已习惯昏暗的、阴沉的冬天。不过这一次，首都的煤烟也被困住了，越积越浓，成了令人窒息的烟雾，也就是烟与雾的混合物。

这些煤烟来自于烧的煤，在家庭壁炉和发电厂里，充满了煤烟和有毒的二氧化硫。有些地方，能见度降到只有几米。救护车服务被暂停，萨德勒之井剧院的一场歌剧在幕间休息时被中止，而史密斯菲尔德农业展上的获奖牛则死亡或不得不被宰杀。

烟雾消散于12月9日，星期二。当时的官员估计超额死亡约4,000人，但卫生部1954年的一份报告把后来的死亡归因于流感。2001年发表于《环境健康展望》的一项研究重新评估了证据，并对这一解释提出了质疑，估计在1952年12月至1953年2月期间约有12,000例超额死亡。

几十年来，伦敦人一直容忍着煤烟，只是把它当成一种让人讨厌的事情。一个元凶就在他们自家的炉栅里闪烁，一个温暖与舒适的来源，如此习以为常，以至于很少有人想到去指责它。这种自满，或许有助于解释政府勉强的回应。政府顶住了要求调查的压力，直到1953年的5月。

改革被证明是旷日持久的，并被官方的惰性拖慢了。《清洁空气法》于1956年7月5日成为法律，此时距那场烟雾已过去三年半。该法授权市镇议会设立无烟区，从源头上遏制煤烟。英国家庭深受喜爱的、温馨的炉膛，原来一直都在主要的肇事者之列。

词汇与表达

stagnant adj.
凝滞的
5 December 1952, cold, stagnant air

descended on v.
笼罩降临了
stagnant air descended on London.

Overhead adv.
头顶上方

lid n.
盖子

chill n.
寒气

captive adj.
困

accustomed to adj.
习惯
accustomed to murky, dreary winters.

murky adj.
昏暗的
accustomed to murky, dreary winters.

dreary adj.
阴沉的

smoke n.
烟

choking adj.
令人窒息的
thickening into a choking smog, a mix

smog n.
烟雾
thickening into a choking smog, a mix

fog n.
雾

domestic adj.
家庭

fireplaces n.
壁炉

power stations n.
发电厂

laden with adj.
充满了
was laden with soot and noxious

noxious adj.
有毒的
with soot and noxious sulphur dioxide.

visibility n.
能见度
In places, visibility fell to a few

Ambulance n.
救护车

suspended v.
暂停
Ambulance services were suspended,

interval n.
幕间休息

cattle n.
牛

agricultural adj.
农业

slaughtered v.
宰杀

dissipated v.
消散
The smog dissipated on Tuesday 9

excess adj.
超额
at the time put the excess deaths at

influenza n.
流感

词汇与表达（续）

reassessed v.
重新评估了
reassessed the evidence

cast doubt on phr.
对……提出了质疑
and cast doubt on that explanation,

explanation n.
解释

tolerated v.
容忍

nuisance n.
让人讨厌的事情
had tolerated the smoke as a nuisance.

villain n.
元凶

flickered v.
闪烁

warmth n.
温暖

comfort n.
舒适

habitual adj.
习以为常
of warmth and comfort so habitual

accuse v.
指责

complacency n.
自满
Such complacency may help to explain

grudging adj.
勉强的
the government's grudging response.

response n.
回应

withstood v.
顶住了

inquiry n.
调查
for an inquiry until May 1953.

protracted adj.
旷日持久的
Reform proved protracted, slowed by

inertia n.
惰性
slowed by official inertia.

Act n.
法

empowered v.
授权
It empowered municipal councils to

municipal adj.
市镇

smokeless adj.
无烟

combating v.
遏制

source n.
源头

cosy adj.
温馨的

hearth n.
炉膛

beloved of adj.
深受喜爱的

offenders n.
肇事者

文章简述

- 困住：1952年12月5至9日，伦敦上方暖空气像盖子压住冷空气，煤烟无法散去，形成致命烟雾。
- 源头：家庭壁炉和发电厂烧煤，释放烟尘及有毒二氧化硫；熟悉的温暖炉火也是污染元凶。
- 瘫痪：局部能见度仅几米，救护车停运、演出中止，农业展的牛也死亡或被迫宰杀。
- 复核：官方初估比常态多死亡约4000人，后续死亡曾被归于流感；2001年研究重估1952年12月至1953年2月，多死亡约1.2万人。
- 改革：政府拖延调查与改革，直到三年半后的1956年才制定《清洁空气法》，授权设无烟区，从源头控烟。